

The Optimal Number of Naps

Findings from a subject who slept through the study

Ada Lovelace [ORCID](#)^{1,2}, Charles Babbage [ORCID](#)²

¹ Institute for Applied Statistics · ² Analytical Society

March 2026

The problem

Nobody agrees on how many naps a day is correct. We asked the only expert on the subject and he fell asleep during the question.

- Recruit one dog.
- Watch him for a week.
- Write down every time he stops moving.



The instrument

01

Two ways to count a nap

Strict

- Eyes fully closed.
- Tail completely still.
- Survives one doorbell.

Generous

- Eyes mostly closed.
- Tail negotiable.
- He looks comfortable, so it counts.

One pass of the counter

```
def count_naps(dog, hours):  
    return [h for h in hours  
            if dog.is_horizontal(h)]
```

Caveat

Sitting upright with both eyes closed remains contested.

In practice

02

A well- behaved subject

The method requires a
subject who stays put.
This one is world class.



What it costs him

Naps

3

11

Hours

4.1

9.8

asleep

stirring

doorbell